

Spirit Regeneration

doc-spirit-regeneration

Pneumatology · Work · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

The Holy Spirit is the agent of regeneration, granting new birth to those dead in sin.

In plain language

The Bible's words for new birth and renewal consistently put the Holy Spirit in the agent position. In John 3 the verb 'to beget' (gennao) appears in the passive 'be done to' voice, parsed as aorist passive (a completed past action where the subject is acted upon) and perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands, in the same passive voice), and is paired with the preposition 'out of' (ek) plus 'Spirit' (pneuma). That is the grammar of source. The one being born does nothing, the Spirit does the begetting. Jesus then likens the Spirit to wind that blows where it wills, so the action is free and not under human control. Titus 3:5 reinforces this with 'rebirth' (palingenesia) and 'renewal' (anakainosis), where 'of the Holy Spirit' (pneumatōs hagiou) is a genitive of source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) naming the Holy Spirit as the one producing the renewal, and the verse explicitly excludes works of righteousness as cause. John 6:63 sharpens the contrast, the Spirit is the one giving life, 'life-giving' (zoopoion), and the flesh profits nothing. The Old Testament root is in Ezekiel 36:26-27, where God speaks in the first person, I will give a new heart, I will remove the heart of stone, I will put my Spirit within you, and the gift of his 'Spirit' or 'breath' (ruach) produces the new walk. Across these passages the pattern is uniform, the Spirit is named, the human is the recipient, the new condition is the result, so the bare claim that the Spirit regenerates is strongly grounded. Two questions stay open because the words do not settle them. First, in John 3:5 born of water and Spirit, and in Titus born through the washing, the term water can mean baptism or can figure cleansing, and the grammar permits both. Second, the canon does not rank or time the new birth against faith, and it names several means for the same begetting, since 1 Peter says we are born again through the living word and through the resurrection while John names the Spirit. The Spirit as agent is clear. The order and the role of baptism are the parts the vocabulary leaves underdetermined.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0068	אֶבֶן	even	stone	
H1320	בָּשָׂר	basar	flesh	270
H2319	חֹדֶשׁ	chadash	New (Gate)	53
H2421	חַיָּה	chayah	to live	262
H3820	לֵב	leb	heart	595
H5414	נָתַן	nathan	to give	2,011
H6213	עָשָׂה	asah	to make	1,656
H7307	רוּחַ	ruach	spirit	378

G0313	ἀναγεννάω	anagennao	to beget	3
G0342	ἀνακαίνωσις	anakainosis	renewal	2
G0509	ἄνωθεν	anōthen	from above/again	13
G1080	γεννάω	gennao	to beget	98
G1537	ἐξ	ek	out from	
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G2227	ζωοποιέω	zoopoieo	to make alive	11
G2937	κτίσις	ktisis	creation	19
G3824	παλιγγενεσία	palingenesia	regeneration	2
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4561	σὰρξ	sarx	flesh	152
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	113
G5204	ῥῶδρ	hudōr, hudatos	water	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern anchors new birth in divine, specifically Spirit, agency across both Testaments. In John 3:5 the verb 'be born' (γεννηθῇ) is aorist passive subjunctive (a completed past action in the passive 'be done to' voice expressing a conditional possibility), and in John 3:6 and 3:8 the participles 'having been born' (γεγεννημένον) and 'one who has been born' (γεγεννημένος) are perfect passive participles (a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive 'be done to' voice), all governed by the preposition 'out of' (ἐκ) plus a genitive of source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form), namely 'out of water and Spirit' (ἐξ ὕδατος καὶ πνεύματος) and 'out of the Spirit' (ἐκ τοῦ πνεύματος). The passive voice places the human in the patient role and names 'Spirit' (πνεῦμα) as the source, and the wordplay between 'Spirit' (πνεῦμα) and 'blows' (πνεῖ) in John 3:8 casts that source as sovereign. Titus 3:5 makes the agency explicit: 'he saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewing of the Holy Spirit' (ἔσωσεν ἡμᾶς διὰ λουτροῦ παλιγγενεσίας καὶ ἀνακαινώσεως πνεύματος ἁγίου), where the genitive 'of the Holy Spirit' (πνεύματος ἁγίου) is the source of the renewal and 'not from works' (οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων) excludes human work. John 6:63 fixes 'the Spirit' (τὸ πνεῦμα) as 'the one giving life' (τὸ ζωοποιούν) while 'the flesh profits nothing' (ἡ σὰρξ οὐκ ὠφελεῖ οὐδέν). Ezekiel 36:26-27 supplies the prophetic substrate (foundation laid down earlier in Scripture) with God in the first person giving a new heart and putting his 'Spirit' or 'breath' (נִשְׁמָה) within. What the vocabulary does NOT settle is the ordo (the order of salvation events), whether this Spirit-birth precedes or accompanies faith, and whether 'water' (ῥῶδρ) denotes baptism, since 1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23 attribute the same begetting to God through resurrection and through the living word.

Scripture

John.3.5 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1080 γεννηθῆ, G1537 ἐξ, G4151 πνεύματος

Force. MorphGNT (the morphological tagging of the Greek New Testament) parses 'be born' (γεννηθῆ) as aorist passive subjunctive (a completed past action in the passive 'be done to' voice, expressed as a conditional possibility), third singular, governed by 'out of water and Spirit' (ἐξ ὕδατος καὶ πνεύματος). The passive voice with the prepositional source 'out of' (ἐκ) presents the Spirit as the one effecting the begetting and the human subject as patient (the one acted upon). The condition 'unless' (ἐὰν μὴ) ties entry into 'the kingdom of God' (τὴν βασιλείαν τοῦ θεοῦ) to this Spirit-effected birth. Whether 'water' (ὕδατος) names baptism is left open by the syntax, but 'Spirit' (πνεύματος) remains the second genitive of source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) either way.

John.3.6 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1080 γεγεννημένον, G4151 πνεύματος, G4561 σαρκός

Force. The perfect passive participle 'that which has been born' (γεγεννημένον), a completed action whose result still stands in the passive 'be done to' voice, parsed XPP in MorphGNT (the morphological tagging of the Greek New Testament), appears twice with paired prepositional sources. 'Out of the flesh' (ἐκ τῆς σαρκός) produces 'flesh' (σάρξ) and 'out of the Spirit' (ἐκ τοῦ πνεύματος) produces 'spirit' (πνεῦμα). The grammar locates origin in the Spirit and identifies the resulting nature as spirit, ruling out fleshly self-generation. The two genitive sources (nouns in the 'from-X' grammatical form) are set in flat contrast, not ranked in time.

John.3.7 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1080 γεννηθῆναι, G0509 ἄνωθεν

Force. The aorist passive infinitive 'to be born' (γεννηθῆναι), a completed past action in the passive 'be done to' voice expressed as a verbal noun, with the adverb 'from above or again' (ἄνωθεν) and the impersonal verb 'it is necessary' (δεῖ) marks the necessity of a begetting from outside the recipient. The word 'from above or again' (ἄνωθεν) is polysemous (carries multiple senses), attested elsewhere as 'from above' spatially in John 3:31 and Matthew 27:51 and as 'from the beginning or again' temporally in Luke 1:3. Both senses keep the begetting non-self-originated, so the agency claim holds on either reading.

John.3.8 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G1080 γεγεννημένος

Force. The clause 'the Spirit blows where it wills' (τὸ πνεῦμα ὅπου θέλει πνεῖ) exploits the wordplay between 'Spirit' (πνεῦμα) and 'blows' (πνεῖ) to depict the Spirit acting freely and unobservably, and 'so is everyone who has been born of the Spirit' (οὕτως ἐστὶν πᾶς ὁ γεγεννημένος ἐκ τοῦ πνεύματος) applies that pattern to everyone begotten of the Spirit. 'It wills' (θέλει) gives the Spirit volition (a will to choose), placing agency on the Spirit side, not the recipient.

Titus.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3824 παλιγγενεσίας, G0342 ἀνακαινώσεως, G4151 πνεύματος

Force. 'He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewing of the Holy Spirit' (ἔσωσεν ἡμᾶς διὰ λουτροῦ παλιγγενεσίας καὶ ἀνακαινώσεως πνεύματος ἁγίου) links salvation to a rebirth-washing and a Spirit-renewal. MorphGNT (the morphological tagging of the Greek New Testament) marks 'of rebirth' (παλιγγενεσίας) and 'of renewing' (ἀνακαινώσεως) as genitives (nouns in the 'of-X' grammatical form) and 'of the Holy Spirit' (πνεύματος ἁγίου) as a following genitive that names the Holy Spirit as the source of the renewal. The phrase 'not from works done in righteousness' (οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων τῶν ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ) excludes human work as cause and 'according to his mercy' (κατὰ τὸ αὐτοῦ ἔλεος) locates the cause in divine mercy.

John.6.63 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G2227 ζωοποιεῖν, G4561 σὰρξ

Force. The present active participle 'the life-giving one' (τὸ ζωοποιεῖν), neuter, ongoing in force, agrees with 'the Spirit' (τὸ πνεῦμα) and attributes life-giving action to the Spirit, while 'the flesh profits nothing' (ἡ σὰρξ οὐκ ὠφελεῖ οὐδέν) strips the flesh of any contribution. The neuter agreement and the verbal force fix the Spirit as the life-giver in direct antithesis to flesh.

Ezek.36.26 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H5414 נתן, H3820 לב, H2319 תדש, H1320 בשר

Force. Three first-person verbs with God as subject, 'and I will give a new heart' (וְנָתַתִּי לְבָב תְּדִשׁ), 'and I will remove the heart of stone' (וְהִסְרֹתִי לְבָב הָאֲבֵן), 'and I will give a heart of flesh' (וְנָתַתִּי לְבָב בָּשָׂר), present unilateral divine action that replaces a heart of stone with a heart of flesh. The ETCBC (Eep Talstra Centre for Bible and Computer) clause data marks God as predicate-subject and the people as complement, giving God the agency and humanity the recipient role.

Ezek.36.27 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H7307 רוח, H5414 נתן, H6213A עשה

Force. 'And my Spirit I will put within you' (וְנָתַתִּי רוּחִי אֵתְכֶם) identifies God's own 'Spirit' or 'breath' (רוח) as the gift placed within. The waw-consecutive (the Hebrew narrative connector that strings actions together) 'and I will cause' (וְעָשִׂיתִי) connects this Spirit-gift to resulting obedience, walking in God's statutes, making the placed Spirit the agent that produces the new walk. The word 'Spirit' or 'breath' (רוח) occurs 378 times in the canon, so its sense is well triangulated, and here the first-person suffix 'my Spirit' (רוחִי) fixes it as God's own Spirit.

1Pet.1.23 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0313 ἀναγεννημένοι

Force. 'Having been born again' (ἀναγεννημένοι) is a perfect passive participle (a completed action whose result still stands in the passive 'be done to' voice) of the verb 'to beget again' (ἀναγεννάω), having been begotten again, but the prepositional instrument is 'through the living word of God' (διὰ λόγου ζῶντος θεοῦ), through the living word of God, not the Spirit. This is recorded as complicating because the same begetting event is here tied to the word, showing the canon names more than one instrument for the new birth and does not rank them.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Ezek.36.26	Deut.30.6	tsk	1
Ezek.36.26	Ezek.11.19	tsk	1
John.3.6	Ezek.11.19	tsk	1
Ezek.36.27	Ezek.37.14	tsk	1
Ezek.36.27	Ezek.37.24	tsk	1
John.6.63	Gen.2.7	tsk	1
John.6.63	John.6.68	tsk	1
John.3.8	John.1.13	tsk	1
John.3.8	Job.37.10	tsk	1
John.3.5	John.3.3	tsk	1
John.3.7	John.3.3	tsk	1
Titus.3.5	Ps.51.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.3.5 · addressed

The phrase 'out of water and Spirit' (ἐξ ὕδατος καὶ πνεύματος) can be read as two distinct sources or as one Spirit-cleansing event. On a sacramental reading (one that treats the rite as causing the spiritual effect) 'water' (ὕδατος) names baptismal water, on a non-sacramental reading it figures cleansing or the word. Either way 'Spirit' (πνεύματος) remains the second genitive of source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form), and the parallel in John 3:6 and 3:8 reduces the recurring source to 'out of the Spirit' (ἐκ τοῦ πνεύματος), so Spirit agency holds. The proposition under test asks only whether the Spirit regenerates, which the syntax answers yes, and not whether water means baptism, which it leaves open.

Titus.3.5 · addressed

'Washing of rebirth' (λουτροῦ παλιγγενεσίας) could be read as a ritual washing that itself produces rebirth, shifting agency to a rite. But the syntax pairs it with 'and renewing of the Holy Spirit' (καὶ ἀνακαινώσεως πνεύματος ἁγίου), the controlling verb 'he saved' (ἔσωσεν) is governed by 'according to his mercy' (κατὰ τὸ αὐτοῦ ἔλεος), and the contrast 'not from works' (οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων) excludes human contribution. The genitive 'of the Holy Spirit' (πνεύματος ἁγίου), a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form, modifies 'renewing' (ἀνακαινώσεως) as source, so the Spirit remains the agent of renewal whatever 'washing' (λουτροῦ) designates.

1Pet.1.23 · unaddressed

Not resolved because it bears on the contested scope rather than the bare proposition. 'Having been born again' (ἀναγεννημένοι), begotten again, is here 'through the living word of God' (διὰ λόγου ζῶντος θεοῦ), through the living word, and 1 Peter 1:3 attributes the same begetting to God 'through resurrection' (διὰ ἀναστάσεως), through the resurrection. The Spirit is not named as instrument in these verses. This shows the canon presents the new birth with several named means, God, word, resurrection, and elsewhere the Spirit, and the vocabulary does not rank or sequence them, which is exactly the underdetermined ordo (order of salvation events) the proposition does not require settling.

John.1.13 · addressed

'Who were born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God' (οἱ οὐκ ἐξ αἱμάτων οὐδὲ ἐκ θελήματος σαρκὸς οὐδὲ ἐκ θελήματος ἀνδρὸς ἀλλ' ἐκ θεοῦ ἐγεννήθησαν) names God as the source of begetting and explicitly excludes human will, but does not name the Spirit. Read with John 3:5-8, where the Spirit is the specific agent of God's begetting, this verse is consistent and reinforces non-human agency rather than competing with Spirit agency.

Concordance traversed

G1080, G0313, G0509, G2227, G3824, G0342, G4151, G4561, G2222, G2937, G4982, G5204, H7307, H3820, H5414, H1320, H2319, H6213A, H2421, H0068

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No anchor verse lies in the ingested ECM (Editio Critica Maior, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so the apparatus (the listing of textual variants) was not consulted for them and no variant signal is invented. The supplied bundle lists zero variant units for John 3:5-8, Titus 3:5, and John 6:63 that would touch the agency of 'Spirit' (πνεῦμα). Ezekiel 36:26-27 is Old Testament and outside ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope, with stable Masoretic (the traditional Hebrew text) readings for 'Spirit' or 'breath' (רוּחַ), 'heart' (לֵב), and 'to give' (נָתַן).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, sacramental_realism, ordo_salutis_monergism, ordo_salutis_synergism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenantal_continuity: affirms · Reads Ezekiel 36:26-27 as the prophetic substrate (foundation laid down earlier in Scripture) that John 3 and Titus 3 fulfill, with the same divine 'Spirit' or 'breath' (πνεῦμα) and 'Spirit' (πνεῦμα) as the agent of inner renewal across both Testaments. The grammar in both, first-person divine verbs in Ezekiel and passive begetting verbs in John, locates agency in God's Spirit on either side of the canon.

discontinuity_dispensational: affirms · Even on a strict New Testament reading that does not lean on the Ezekiel link, John 3:5-8, John 6:63, and Titus 3:5 lexically locate regeneration in 'Spirit' (πνεῦμα) as agent through passive begetting verbs and a Spirit-source genitive (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form), so the proposition holds on the Greek alone.

baptismal_regeneration_reading: affirms · Takes 'out of water' (ἐξ ὕδατος) in John 3:5 and 'washing' (λουτροῦ) in Titus 3:5 as baptismal water, so the Spirit works regeneration in and through the washing. On this reading the Spirit is still the named agent, 'out of the Spirit' (ἐκ τοῦ πνεύματος) and 'of the Holy Spirit' (πνεύματος ἁγίου), so the bare proposition that the Spirit regenerates is affirmed, while the means is held to include the rite.

faith_precedes_or_accompanies_reading: affirms · Holds that the Spirit gives new life in connection with believing rather than as a prior cause, citing that 1 Peter 1:23 ties the new birth to the word that is heard and believed. The Spirit remains the agent of life-giving, 'life-giving one' (ζωοποιοῦν), so the proposition is affirmed, while the timing relative to faith is read as concurrent.

monergistic_prior_regeneration_reading: affirms · Holds that the Spirit-birth precedes and enables faith, reading the passive begetting verbs and the wind that blows 'where it wills' (ὅπου θέλει) as marking the Spirit as the sole and prior cause of the new life. The Spirit is the agent, which the proposition affirms, while the priority of regeneration to faith is read as the point of the passives and the volitional 'it wills' (θέλει).

The cross-Testament reading is reinforced by the Spirit-and-new-heart cluster shared by Ezekiel 11:19, Ezekiel 36:26-27, Ezekiel 37:14, and the Johannine and Pauline anchors. The competing lenses differ on two questions the words do not settle, whether 'water' (ὕδατος) and 'washing' (λουτροῦ) mean baptism, and whether the Spirit-birth precedes or accompanies faith, but all five lenses affirm the bare proposition that the Spirit is the agent of regeneration.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem (the proposition under test) names the Spirit as agent and new-birth as result, both of which are lexical, not framework-specific, and are mirrored by the verb 'to beget' (γεννάω) in the passive 'be done to' voice with 'out of the Spirit' (ἐκ πνεύματος), by 'renewing of the Holy Spirit' (ἀνακαίνωσις πνεύματος ἁγίου), and by 'the Spirit is the life-giving one' (τὸ πνεῦμα ζωοποιοῦν). The phrase 'dead in sin' is summary language for the 'flesh' (σάρξ) and stone-heart cluster and preloads no verdict. The stem does not assert an ordo (order of salvation events) or a sacramental theory (one treating a rite as causing the spiritual effect), so it does not smuggle the contested timing or the baptismal question, which remain underdetermined by the vocabulary.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.3.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.3.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.3.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.3.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.3.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.6.63
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.1.23

morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ezek.36.26
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ezek.36.27
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1080
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0509
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2227
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3824
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0342
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0313
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7307
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3820
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2319
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	John.3.5
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ezek.36.26
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.3.5
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ezek.36.27
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Ezek.36.26
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.3.8
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Titus.3.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.6.63

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved